IELTS Turbo · Week 5 · Saturday · Writing and Speaking

Health and lifestyle

1. Read the article once for meaning. 2. Read it again and look at the **highlighted new words** and the **blue phrases** in context. 3. Study the tables. 4. Use at least 5 new words in speaking or writing this week.

Article: Health in the modern age: a lifestyle problem? (190 words)

People are living longer than ever before. **Life expectancy** has risen sharply in most countries, thanks to better **nutrition**, clean water and widespread **vaccination**. Yet this success hides a worrying trend. A **sedentary** lifestyle, combined with too much **processed food**, has pushed up rates of **obesity** and other **chronic** diseases.

Doctors increasingly stress **preventive** care rather than expensive **treatment**. A **balanced diet**, a regular **workout** and enough sleep do more for long-term **well-being** than many medicines, and sleep in particular supports the **immune system**. Public campaigns remind people to watch for early **symptom** signs of illness, while any drug, however useful, may cause a harmful **side effect**.

Health is no longer only about the body. Rising **stress**, loneliness and anxiety have made **mental health** a central concern, and a person struggling with **addiction** needs support, not blame. At the level of **public health**, governments **step in** when an **epidemic** threatens, as recent years have shown. The question is how much responsibility belongs to the state and how much to the individual. Most experts conclude that prevention works best when it **goes hand in hand with** a society that makes healthy choices easy.

Useful phrases from the article

Phrase	Meaning
step in	take action
goes hand in hand with	happens together with

The 20 new words

Word		Meaning	Example
sedentary	adj	involving a lot of sitting	*A sedentary lifestyle increases health risks.*
obesity	n	a serious condition of being very overweight	*Childhood obesity is rising in many countries.*
balanced diet	n	food with the right mix of nutrients	*A balanced diet keeps the body healthy.*
life expectancy	n	how long people usually live	*Life expectancy has risen in the last century.*
chronic	adj	lasting a long time	*Chronic illness needs long-term care.*
preventive	adj	stopping something before it happens	*Preventive medicine saves money.*

well-being	n	the state of being healthy and happy	*Exercise improves mental well-being.*
stress	n	worry that makes you feel tense	*Work stress affects sleep.*
epidemic	n	a disease that spreads quickly in an area	*The flu epidemic closed several schools.*
vaccination	n	an injection that protects from disease	*Vaccination has wiped out smallpox.*
processed food	n	food changed in a factory	*Too much processed food harms health.*
workout	n	a session of exercise	*A short daily workout can improve fitness.*
nutrition	n	the food you need to live and grow	*Good nutrition is vital for children.*
treatment	n	medical care for an illness	*The treatment lasted six months.*
symptom	n	a sign of illness	*A cough is a common symptom of a cold.*
mental health	n	the health of your mind	*Mental health deserves more attention.*
public health	n	the health of a whole population	*Smoking bans improved public health.*
addiction	n	the inability to stop doing something harmful	*Drug addiction destroys families.*
immune system	n	the body's defense against disease	*Sleep strengthens the immune system.*
side effect	n	an unwanted result of a medicine	*The drug has serious side effects.*

Revision: 10 words from last week

Word		Meaning
global warming	n	the rise of Earth's temperature
greenhouse gas	n	gas that traps heat in the air
carbon footprint	n	the carbon dioxide caused by a person or group
renewable	adj	able to be used again naturally
fossil fuels	n	coal, oil and gas
deforestation	n	the cutting down of forests
biodiversity	n	the variety of living things
endangered	adj	at risk of disappearing
sustainable	adj	able to continue without damaging nature
pollution	n	harmful substances in the environment

Practice: fill the gaps

well-being · sedentary · stress · epidemic · immune system · symptom · workout · nutrition

1. Exercise improves mental _____.
2. A _____ lifestyle increases health risks.
3. Work _____ affects sleep.
4. The flu _____ closed several schools.
5. Sleep strengthens the _____.
6. A cough is a common _____ of a cold.
7. A short daily _____ can improve fitness.
8. Good _____ is vital for children.

More words on this topic (not in the article: choose the 10 most useful for you)

balanced (adj): having the right proportions
calorie (n): a unit of food energy
check-up (n): a routine medical examination
contagious (adj): spreading by contact
dehydration (n): loss of too much water from the body
diabetes (n): a disease with too much sugar in the blood
fitness (n): the state of being physically healthy
gym (n): a place for exercise
healthcare (n): medical services
heart disease (n): illness of the heart
hygiene (n): cleanliness to prevent disease
inactive (adj): not doing much exercise
insomnia (n): inability to sleep
junk food (n): unhealthy fast food
malnutrition (n): poor health from lack of food
overweight (adj): heavier than is healthy
painkiller (n): a drug that reduces pain
physical activity (n): movement that exercises the body
physiotherapy (n): treatment by exercise and massage
portion (n): an amount of food served
protein (n): a nutrient that builds the body
relaxation (n): the state of being calm
self-care (n): looking after your own health
sleep deprivation (n): not getting enough sleep
stay in shape (v): to remain fit
take up (v): to start a hobby or activity
cut down on (v): to reduce
wellness (n): good health as an active goal
medical checkup (n): a routine test by a doctor
vitamin (n): a substance needed in small amounts

Topic kit: what to know about this topic

Writing Task 2 questions you may meet

1. Some people think governments should spend more on preventing illness; others think treating illness is more important. Discuss both views.
2. Obesity is increasing around the world. What are the causes and what can be done?
3. Some say people are responsible for their own health; others say the state is. To what extent do you agree?
4. Doing regular exercise is the best way to stay healthy. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Ideas you can use in essays and in speaking

- **For / good:** Prevention, such as vaccination and health education, costs far less than treating serious disease.
- **Against / bad:** Some illnesses cannot be prevented and need expensive modern treatment.
- **For / good:** Sugar and processed food are cheap and heavily advertised, which pushes up obesity.
- **Against / bad:** Sedentary jobs and long commutes leave people little time to exercise.
- **For / good:** Exercise improves mental health as well as the body.
- **Against / bad:** Diet and sleep matter just as much, so exercise alone is not enough.

Speaking

Part 1

- Do you do any sport?
- What do you do to stay healthy?
- Do you eat healthy food?
- Do you sleep well?
- How do you relax when you are stressed?

Part 3

- Why are some people unwilling to exercise?
- Should unhealthy food be taxed?
- Who is responsible for public health?
- How has medicine improved in the last fifty years?

Part 2 cue card. Describe a time you were ill. You should say: when it happened, what was wrong, how you recovered, and explain how you felt.

Answers

1. well-being (well-being)
2. sedentary (sedentary)
3. stress (stress)
4. epidemic (epidemic)
5. immune system (immune system)
6. symptom (symptom)
7. workout (workout)
8. nutrition (nutrition)